CHAPTER 5

More About Methods

So far in this book, we've been defining and using methods without much thought. Now it's time to get into the details.

Defining a Method

As we've seen, a method is defined using the keyword def.

The keyword def creates a method and returns the name of the method as a symbol, which we saw in Specifying Access Control, on page 44 allows us to put decorator methods like private before the declaration.

The body of a method contains normal Ruby expressions. The return value of a method is the value of the last expression executed or the argument of an explicit return expression.

An important fact about def is that if you define a method a second time, Ruby will not raise an error, it will print a warning, then it will just redefine the method using the second definition:

```
class Batman
  def who_is_robin
    puts "Dick Grayson"
  end

  def who_is_robin
    puts "Damian Wayne"
  end
end

Batman.new.who_is_robin
```

produces:

```
Damian Wayne
```

When combined with the ability to reopen classes that we saw in Reopening Classes, on page 49, the ability to redefine methods is an important, but potentially dangerous feature of how classes work.